

When Improvement Fails to Scale: Optimization-Suspension as a Test of Evaluative Control in Mild Anhedonia

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Abstract

Affective change is typically modeled as a graded outcome of reinforcement, engagement, and goal-directed optimization, implying that increased effort or improved strategies should scale positive affect. We test an alternative: that the structure of control itself constrains which experiences are accessible. The present study uses anhedonia as a test case for a broader hypothesis about the structural constraints imposed by evaluative control.

Specifically, sustained coupling between monitoring and corrective processes may systematically exclude forms of experience that do not scale with evaluation. Under this view, some high-intensity or spontaneous affective states remain inaccessible not because of insufficient engagement, but because they are structurally incompatible with evaluative control.

To test this, we contrast standard behavioral activation with an optimization-suspension condition, in which participants act without attempting to improve, monitor, or apply strategies. The key prediction is not simply improvement, but a distinct signature: changes that are discontinuous, highly variable, and decoupled from effort, repetition, and strategy use, with no convergence toward stable behavioral patterns.

If observed, this pattern would challenge models in which affect scales with reinforcement and optimization, and instead suggest that modifying control structure alters the space of accessible experience.

1 Introduction

Contemporary approaches to mild depressive symptoms typically emphasize increasing engagement with rewarding activities, reinforcing positive experiences, and improving cognitive or behavioral strategies. Across behavioral activation and cognitive therapies, improvement is assumed to arise from structured, goal-directed changes in behavior, supported by monitoring and iterative adjustment (Jacobson et al., 2001; Martell et al., 2010; Beck, 2011).

Within these frameworks, positive affect is treated as a graded and producible outcome, increasing as individuals obtain desired outcomes, engage in rewarding activities, or reduce negative cognitions. This assumption aligns with reinforcement learning and contemporary accounts of reward processing, in which affective states are shaped by prediction error, valuation, and goal attainment (Schultz, 2016; Berridge & Kringelbach, 2015; Sutton & Barto, 2018).

Across these approaches, a common structural feature emerges: a tight coupling between discrepancy detection and corrective action, such that deviations from expected states are rapidly minimized through adjustment. While this coupling supports goal-directed behavior and adaptive performance, it may also constrain the dynamics of ongoing experience by preventing discrepancies from persisting as signals.

The present account isolates this coupling as a structural variable. Rather than increasing or decreasing control globally, it tests the effects of temporarily disrupting the transformation of monitored discrepancies into corrective actions.

However, these models rely on processes such as monitoring, comparison, and outcome-based adjustment, which systematically organize behavior around evaluation. In mild depressive states, closely

related processes appear as persistent self-monitoring, rumination, and effortful regulation, suggesting a structural overlap between mechanisms of improvement and mechanisms of maintenance (Edward Watkins, 2008; Susan Nolen-Hoeksema et al., 2008).

This overlap raises a more general question: whether increasing engagement within an evaluative, goal-directed framework is sufficient to alter the underlying dynamics of experience, or whether the structure of control itself constrains what kinds of changes can occur. In particular, it remains unclear whether processes that rely on monitoring and outcome-based adjustment may, under some conditions, also limit access to forms of experience that do not scale with evaluation or control.

The present work explores this possibility by testing an intervention that does not introduce new strategies, skills, or goals, but instead locally suspends goal-directed optimization processes during ordinary activities. Rather than attempting to increase positive outcomes, the intervention alters the conditions under which behavior is selected, monitored, and adjusted.

This approach does not introduce an alternative regulatory strategy (e.g., attentional stabilization or non-judgmental monitoring), but instead targets the temporary absence of optimization itself. See Appendix C for a structured comparison with mindfulness-based approaches. Unlike mindfulness or attentional training, it does not replace one form of control with another, but removes the possibility of control-based improvement altogether.

The intervention is defined by the absence of a stabilizable procedure: the intervention is structurally incompatible with optimization: any attempt to improve, stabilize, or reproduce it reconstitutes the very control loop it is designed to suspend.

To examine this, the study contrasts an optimization-suspension condition with an active control condition grounded in conventional goal-directed engagement. The primary prediction is not a gradual improvement driven by increased activity or reinforcement, but a qualitative shift in engagement characterized by reduced rumination and less effortful regulation.

This perspective is consistent with a broader theoretical account in which access to certain affective states is constrained not only by external conditions or reinforcement histories, but by the degree to which ongoing experience is subjected to evaluative control (Morin, 2026). The core hypothesis is that evaluative control, while typically considered adaptive, may under certain conditions constrain access to specific forms of experience, including spontaneous engagement and high-intensity positive affect. This implies that existing models may be well-specified for optimization-dependent changes, yet structurally unable to capture forms of experience that emerge only under reduced evaluative coupling. Anhedonia may not solely reflect a deficit in reward processing, but a hyper-stabilization of the coupling between monitoring and corrective processes. The question is not whether improvement occurs, but whether its structure violates standard model predictions: what if certain experiences are not low because we fail to optimize, but because optimization structurally prevents them from occurring?

2 Methods

This is not an intervention designed to produce improvement, but a manipulation designed to test whether improvement itself is constrained by control structure. If improvement depends on reducing optimization, then improvement cannot be reliably pursued as a goal. The manipulation is not validated by adherence to a procedure, but by a dissociation pattern predicted in advance.

2.1 Design

The study uses a randomized between-subjects field design comparing two conditions: an optimization-suspension condition and an active control condition based on conventional behavioral activation principles. The design is intended to test whether reducing evaluative control produces a pattern of change distinct from improvement driven by activity selection, reinforcement, and iterative adjustment.

The key manipulation is not the amount of activity performed, but the control structure under which ordinary activity occurs. In the active control condition, participants are encouraged to select, repeat, monitor, and adjust activities according to their expected benefits. In the optimization-suspension condition, participants are instructed to temporarily suspend these processes during everyday behavior. Both conditions operate within the same range of everyday activities. The manipulation targets the control policy applied to these activities, not their content, intensity, or cognitive demand.

2.2 Participants

Participants are adults from the general population reporting mild depressive symptoms, as assessed by a standard self-report measure such as the PHQ-9. Exclusion criteria include moderate to severe depression, current suicidality, bipolar or psychotic disorder, and recent changes in psychiatric medication.

2.3 Procedure

Participants complete baseline measures and are then randomly assigned to one of the two conditions. The intervention period lasts 10 to 14 days and takes place in participants' ordinary daily environments.

No daily reminders, ecological prompts, or compliance checks are used during the intervention period. This choice is part of the experimental design: repeated prompting or self-monitoring would reintroduce evaluative control and would therefore confound the manipulation.

At the end of the intervention period, participants complete the same measures and provide a short free-text report describing their experience.

2.4 Optimization-Suspension Condition

The intervention targets the coupling between monitoring and corrective processes. Participants are not instructed to reduce monitoring itself, but to refrain from converting ongoing signals into adjustments, improvements, or strategies. In this sense, the manipulation does not eliminate control processes, but disrupts their stabilization into a closed monitoring-correction loop. If it can be trained, improved, or applied consistently, it is not this intervention.

They are then given the following instruction:

At times, act without trying to do better. Do not check whether it works. Do not analyze what is happening. Do not try to improve the method. Sometimes change, stop, or leave things incomplete without reason. There is nothing to achieve, nothing to improve, and nothing to verify. Even if something feels better, do not try to repeat it.

Examples are provided only to make the instruction intelligible: walking without a destination, reading unrelated passages, stopping when something becomes engaging, asking a question without answering it, performing a small purposeless action, or briefly treating an object as important and then doing nothing with it. Participants are explicitly told not to treat these examples as a routine or protocol.

This approach should not be interpreted as a relaxation technique, a mindfulness practice, or a form of attentional training. Unlike approaches that introduce alternative forms of regulation, the present intervention does not provide any attentional anchor, does not instruct participants to maintain a particular state, and does not require consistency or continuity over time. No stable strategy is introduced to replace goal-directed optimization. Any attempt to stabilize attention, maintain a specific mode of engagement, or apply the intervention consistently would reintroduce evaluative control and undermine the manipulation.

2.5 Active Control Condition

Participants in the active control condition are instructed to engage in small, manageable activities intended to improve mood or well-being. They are encouraged to choose activities they expect to be beneficial, plan them when possible, repeat activities that seem effective, notice their effects, and adjust behavior based on outcomes.

This condition preserves preference-based selection, goal-directed engagement, monitoring, and iterative optimization.

2.6 Measures

The primary outcome is change in depressive symptoms from baseline to post-intervention. Secondary outcomes include rumination, anhedonia, perceived effort, and spontaneous engagement. In addition to depressive symptoms, anhedonia will be assessed using a validated self-report measure (e.g., SHAPS or TEPS), allowing dissociation between general mood improvement and changes in reward sensitivity.

The primary outcome remains change in depressive symptoms, while anhedonia is treated as a key secondary construct.

Participants also provide a brief qualitative report. These reports are used to assess whether the two conditions produced different experiential profiles. The optimization-suspension condition is expected to produce reports of reduced checking, reduced effortful regulation, interrupted or non-directed activity, and spontaneous engagement. The active control condition is expected to produce reports of planned activity, deliberate selection, monitoring of effects, and strategy adjustment.

The optimization-suspension condition should therefore not be understood as a behavioral technique with measurable adherence criteria. Its purpose is not to induce correct performance, but to locally disrupt the ordinary loops through which behavior is selected, monitored, evaluated, and improved. For this reason, the critical outcome is not procedural conformity, but the emergence of a distinct pattern of change. Evidence for the manipulation would consist in reduced checking, reduced effortful regulation, weak or absent associations between improvement and strategy use, and qualitative reports of spontaneous or non-directed engagement. After the intervention period, participants are asked whether they noticed episodes of checking, trying to improve, repeating what worked, or deliberately applying the instruction. These questions are retrospective and are not presented during the intervention, in order to avoid turning the manipulation into an object of monitoring.

2.7 Predicted Signature

The main prediction is not simply that the optimization-suspension condition improves mood.

Compared with the active control condition, optimization-suspension should show:

- reduced rumination and increased spontaneous, non-goal-directed engagement;
- weak or absent association between improvement and effort, repetition, or strategy use;
- absence of convergence toward stable behavioral patterns, with persistently high inter-individual variability;
- reports of sudden or unanticipated shifts in engagement or affective tone, not attributable to gradual improvement or identifiable behavioral precursors
- qualitative reports indicating reduced checking and reduced outcome-monitoring.

This predicted profile distinguishes the hypothesis from standard behavioral activation accounts, in which improvement is expected to scale with activity, reinforcement, planning, and successful adjustment. The manipulation is validated indirectly through the structure of outcomes, not adherence.

The signature would be a dissociation between improvement and effort, repetition, or strategy use. This pattern would not only indicate improvement, but a pattern that standard models would interpret as noise or non-compliance: variability, discontinuity, and lack of strategy dependence are not measurement artifacts but predicted outcomes of reduced evaluative structuring. Any systematic coupling between improvement and effort, repetition, or strategy use would directly contradict the hypothesis. Under a decoupled regime, monitored signals are not systematically transformed into corrective actions. As a result, changes in experience are not expected to track behavior, effort, or repetition. Instead, they may appear temporally discontinuous and statistically unstructured relative to prior actions.

Accordingly, within-subject time series are not expected to exhibit smooth or monotonic trends. The absence of progressive build-up or dose-response relationship is a central feature of the predicted outcome structure.

A critical aspect of this prediction is that it is falsifiable at the level of outcome structure. If improvement in the optimization-suspension condition shows reliable positive associations with effort, repetition, or strategy use, or follows a gradual, cumulative trajectory comparable to the active control condition, the hypothesis is contradicted. Rather than predicting differences in overall improvement, the present account predicts that the two conditions will produce distinct patterns of change, with optimization-suspension yielding non-linear, discontinuous dynamics that standard models would interpret as noise or non-compliance. If the predicted pattern is observed, models that rely on effort-dependent scaling are not merely incomplete, but structurally mis-specified for this class of phenomena.

Metric	Standard Models Prediction	Optimization-Suspension Prediction
Intra-subject correlation (effort vs improvement)	Positive correlation (more effort → more improvement)	Near-zero or inconsistent correlation
Inter-subject variability over time	Decreases (convergence toward effective strategies)	Remains high (no convergence)
Within-subject temporal pattern	Gradual, cumulative improvement	Discontinuous, non-linear change
Strategy extraction	Identifiable and reusable patterns	No stable pattern can be extracted
Dependence on repetition	Improvement scales with repetition/practice	No reliable relation to repetition
Qualitative reports	Goal-directed, strategy-based	Reduced checking, spontaneous, non-directed

Table 1: Predicted differences in outcome structure between standard goal-directed models and optimization-suspension.

In addition to the absence of gradual improvement, the temporal profile of change is expected to show discontinuities at the individual level. Participants may report sudden shifts in engagement or affective tone that are not preceded by progressive improvement or identifiable behavioral precursors. These changes are not expected to follow a cumulative trajectory, nor to stabilize over time. Instead, they may appear as isolated transitions, without clear onset conditions or reproducible triggers.

2.8 Rumination alone is not sufficient

A reduction in rumination alone is not sufficient to account for the predicted pattern of change. Standard accounts would expect improvements to correlate with reduced negative processing and increased effective behavior over time. By contrast, the present hypothesis predicts a decoupling between change and effort, repetition, or strategy use. Improvements may occur without identifiable behavioral causes, fail to accumulate over time, and remain highly variable across individuals. Such a profile cannot be explained by rumination reduction alone, but reflects a broader shift in the structure of control governing experience.

2.9 Disambiguating the predicted pattern from noise, non-compliance, and expectancy effects

A central challenge for the present account is that the predicted outcome structure, high variability, weak associations with effort, and absence of convergence, may be superficially indistinguishable from noise or non-compliance under standard analytic assumptions. This objection can be addressed by specifying structural constraints that distinguish these alternatives.

Random noise predicts variability without systematic dissociation: it does not selectively eliminate correlations between improvement and effort or strategy use while preserving coherent qualitative reports. Non-compliance predicts unconstrained heterogeneity, with no consistent reductions in rumination or shared experiential features across participants. Expectancy-based accounts, by contrast, predict progressive stabilization, including increasing alignment between behavior and outcome and convergence toward effective strategies over time.

The present account uniquely predicts a different pattern: detectable change combined with weak or absent correlations with effort and strategy use, sustained inter-individual variability without convergence, and coherent qualitative reports of reduced evaluative control. These features must co-occur. Any reliable increase in alignment between behavior, effort, and outcome, or convergence toward stable behavioral patterns, would contradict the hypothesis.

2.10 Illustrative individual trajectory, reconstructed trajectory

To clarify the predicted structure, consider a typical within-subject trajectory under the optimization-suspension condition.

A participant may report no noticeable change for several consecutive days, despite engaging in a range of everyday activities. No specific behavior, context, or repetition appears to produce any effect. Then, a sudden shift in engagement or affective tone may occur on a given day, without identifiable precursor conditions. This shift is not preceded by gradual improvement, increased effort, or successful strategy use.

Following this transition, the state may persist transiently or disappear without clear cause. Subsequent attempts to reproduce the experience, repeat prior actions, or identify what “worked” do not reliably lead to reoccurrence. Across the full observation period, no stable mapping emerges between actions and outcomes.

When analyzed quantitatively, such a trajectory would show:

no consistent correlation between effort and improvement, no cumulative effect of repetition, no convergence toward effective behavioral patterns over time.

Despite this, subjective reports remain coherent, describing reduced checking, reduced effortful regulation, and episodes of spontaneous or non-directed engagement.

This pattern differs from random noise, which would not preserve coherent experiential reports, and from expectancy-driven change, which would predict increasing alignment between behavior and outcome over time. Under standard models, such a trajectory would be classified as noise or non-compliance. In the present framework, it constitutes the primary signal.

3 Discussion

This account may extend beyond anhedonia and apply to other domains in which access to specific experiential states appears constrained despite intact capacity. In particular, processes such as creativity, open-ended exploration, and spontaneous engagement may rely on forms of experience that do not scale with evaluation, optimization, or goal-directed control.

Under sustained evaluative coupling, behavior is continuously shaped toward convergence, efficiency, and outcome alignment. While this supports performance, it may simultaneously suppress modes of engagement characterized by variability, divergence, or non-instrumental structure. In this sense, reduced creativity or diminished exploratory behavior may not reflect a deficit in generative capacity, but a constraint imposed by persistent evaluative structuring.

Similarly, high-intensity affective states, including those described as immersive, vivid, or unusually salient, may depend on the persistence of signals that are not immediately transformed into corrective action. When evaluative coupling is reduced, these signals may propagate and amplify, producing qualitatively distinct experiential configurations. Under high evaluative load, by contrast, such signals are rapidly attenuated or redirected, limiting access to these states. If confirmed, the results would suggest that some affective changes are not only independent of optimization, but systematically obscured by methodologies that assume gradual, effort-dependent scaling.

Spontaneous engagement may reflect a related mechanism. Rather than emerging from deliberate selection or optimization, it may arise when behavior is no longer continuously shaped by outcome-based evaluation. In this case, engagement is not constructed through strategy, but appears as a byproduct of reduced constraint on ongoing activity.

Across these domains, the present framework suggests that certain forms of experience are not inaccessible due to lack of effort, skill, or reinforcement, but because they are structurally incompatible with sustained evaluative control. Accordingly, modifying the structure of control may expand the range of accessible experiential states without producing improvements that are cumulative, stable, or optimizable.

4 Limitations

Several limitations follow directly from the assumptions being tested and should be interpreted in that context.

First, the optimization-suspension condition does not allow for standard compliance assessment. There is no stable behavioral criterion for correct implementation, since attempts to monitor or standardize behavior reintroduce evaluative control. Accordingly, the manipulation must be evaluated through the structure of outcomes rather than procedural fidelity.

Second, the intervention cannot be standardized or replicated in the conventional sense. It cannot be reduced to a fixed protocol or improved through iteration without altering its underlying control structure. Replication therefore depends on preserving the absence of stabilizable procedures, rather than reproducing specific actions.

Third, expectancy effects cannot be fully excluded, but their explanatory scope is constrained. Expectancy-based improvement typically relies on monitoring and reinforcement of perceived effects. By limiting these processes, the present manipulation reduces the capacity for expectancy to accumulate or stabilize. As a result, any change that does not scale with effort, repetition, or strategy use would be difficult to attribute to expectancy alone.

Fourth, the predicted outcome pattern challenges standard distinctions between signal and noise. Variability, discontinuity, and weak dependence on effort or strategy use are treated as predicted features rather than artifacts. This creates an interpretive asymmetry, as conventional analytic frameworks may classify such patterns as non-compliance or random variation.

Fifth, the study is restricted to individuals with mild depressive symptoms and does not address more severe or clinically complex conditions. The relevance of the proposed mechanism beyond this population remains an open empirical question.

Finally, the present work does not aim to produce a scalable or optimizable intervention. Its purpose is to test whether modifying the structure of control alters the range of accessible experiences. The absence of a transferable method is therefore not a practical limitation, but a consequence of the underlying hypothesis.

The absence of fine-grained behavioral measurement is not a limitation but a requirement of the design. The intervention targets the coupling between monitoring and corrective processes, and any attempt to track or evaluate behavior in real time would reintroduce this coupling, thereby altering the phenomenon under investigation. Accordingly, validation is based not on procedural fidelity but on outcome structure. Evidence for the manipulation lies in a distinct signature, namely reduced coupling between change and effort, repetition, or strategy use, alongside increased variability and discontinuity. Under standard assumptions, such patterns may be interpreted as noise or non-compliance. Within the present framework, they constitute the primary signal.

5 Conclusion

The present account tests whether reducing evaluative control not only decreases negative processes such as rumination, but alters the set of accessible experiential states, producing forms of engagement that do not scale with optimization, effort, or reinforcement. Rather than introducing an optimizable intervention, the study tests a constraint on how affective change can occur.

If confirmed, the results would indicate that suspending goal-directed optimization can reduce rumination and effortful self-regulation while increasing spontaneous engagement, without reliance on repetition or strategy. This pattern would contrast with the gradual, effort-dependent improvements predicted by standard behavioral models.

These findings suggest that evaluative control plays a dual role: while it supports adaptive functioning, it may also constrain access to certain forms of experience. Improvement may therefore depend not only on increasing engagement, but on modifying the structure of control itself. Less control may reflect not reduced function, but a shift in control configuration, enabling experiences that remain inaccessible under sustained optimization.

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A Appendix A: Dimensions of Optimization

Evaluative load increases when behavior becomes goal-directed, monitored, compared, optimized, or constrained by expected outcomes. It decreases when these processes are locally suspended without replacement by another control strategy. Participants may recognize that behavior is often guided by attempts to optimize along different dimensions:

- **Reward optimization** – trying to reach, prolong, or maximize a “good” moment
- **Outcome optimization** – acting to obtain a specific result
- **Continuity optimization** – following sequences to completion
- **Attention optimization** – maintaining focus deliberately
- **Understanding optimization** – trying to make sense or extract meaning
- **Self-evaluation optimization** – checking whether one is doing it correctly

These dimensions are provided only as a retrospective framework to recognize where optimization may have occurred. They are not intended to be applied, monitored, or used to guide behavior during the task.

B Appendix B: Taxonomy of Optimization-Suspension and Evaluative Patterns

These examples are not intended to be followed as a procedure, but to illustrate how actions become goal-directed, monitored, compared, or optimized. Participants are introduced to the concept of non-optimization through these examples. During the task, they should not reflect on the concept itself or attempt to apply it deliberately, but maintain a minimal stance such as “ok, don’t optimize,” without further elaboration or monitoring.

Non-optimization is not something to perform correctly. If participants attempt to apply the task, verify whether they are not optimizing, or improve their execution, they are reintroducing goal-directed monitoring. This directly contradicts the task and increases evaluative load.

B.1 A. Patterns that reduce evaluative load

These patterns weaken preference, anticipation, comparison, verification, and outcome-based selection.

1. **Non-preferential selection** Do not rely on a preferred place, option, or stimulus. If a preference appears, do not use it to guide selection.
2. **Absence of goal or destination** Engage in activity without a defined objective. Allow direction to occur without prior planning.
3. **Disruption of continuity** Occasionally stop without reason, then resume. Change direction without prior decision.

4. **Absence of comparison** Do not rely on past experiences to guide current choices.
5. **Absence of verification** Do not check whether something is working. Do not evaluate success or failure.
6. **Absence of analysis** Do not interpret or explain what is happening. Allow thoughts to remain incomplete.
7. **Low-demand play contexts** Engage in simple, non-competitive activities. Avoid scoring, ranking, or progression. Do not attempt to succeed.
8. **Non-sequential reading** Read paragraphs in random order. Do not attempt to reconstruct meaning.
9. **Abandon upon engagement** When something becomes interesting (e.g., a passage or a song), switch immediately.
10. **Non-anticipatory listening** Do not select based on what worked before. Occasionally listen to random segments.
11. **Incomplete questioning** Ask a question without answering it. Let it fade without continuation.
12. **Non-instrumental micro-actions** Perform a small precise action without purpose.
13. **Non-salient consumption** Consume (e.g., food) without treating it as important.
14. **Decoupled salience tagging** Mark an object as important, then do not engage with it.
15. **Suspension of defensiveness and justification** Do not explain or justify actions. Do not defend internal states.

General principle: Across all examples, no goal is pursued, no outcome is evaluated, no improvement is attempted, no verification is performed, and no justification is required. There is nothing to achieve.

Minimal Instructions (Smooth Version)

From time to time, act without trying to do better. Do not check whether it works, and do not analyze what is happening. Avoid turning this into a method or a routine.

Sometimes, change what you are doing without reason. You may stop and resume later, or leave things incomplete. There is no need to follow through, no need to improve, and nothing to verify.

When walking, move without a destination. You may change direction or stop at any moment, without deciding in advance. If you think about going out, do not choose a place for a specific reason or preference.

When reading, you may move between unrelated passages. If something becomes engaging, you can stop immediately and switch to something else.

When listening to music, do not search for a particular moment or effect. Avoid selecting what worked before. You may sometimes stop listening without reason, even when it starts to feel engaging.

You can ask a question and leave it unanswered. Let it fade without trying to resolve it.

You may perform a small action without purpose, then stop without correcting it. For example, aligning an object, then leaving it as it is.

You can choose an object, briefly treat it as important, and then do nothing with it.

In general, act without explaining or justifying what you do, internally or externally. Do not frame your actions as part of a meaningful process.

There is nothing to achieve, nothing to improve, and nothing to check.

B.2 C. Patterns that increase evaluative load (counter-examples)

1. **Goal-directed focus** Trying to perform correctly or maintain controlled attention.
2. **Performance monitoring** Checking whether something is working or evaluating internal state.
3. **Preference-based selection** Choosing what worked before or seeking the best option.
4. **Scarcity framing** Treating the experience as limited or depletable.
5. **Strategy-based behavior** Trying to improve performance or adjusting behavior based on results.

Examples were provided to make the contrast intelligible, not to define a behavioral program. Participants were not asked to reproduce the examples, combine them, or evaluate which ones were effective.

C Appendix C: Suspension of Optimization vs Mindfulness vs Flow

This comparison is provided to prevent misclassification of the manipulation as a form of mindfulness or attentional regulation or flow. The two approaches differ at the level of control structure rather than surface instructions.

Dimension	Optimization-Suspension	Mindfulness
Nature	Absence of strategy	Explicit strategy
Goal	None, nothing to achieve	Regulation, reduction of distress
Monitoring	Must be absent	Maintained (meta-awareness)
Attention	Unstabilized, free to drift	Stabilized (breath, body, etc.)
Application	Non-repeatable, non-optimizable	Repeatable, trainable
Verification	Prohibited	Implicit (checking presence/awareness)
Improvement	Impossible by design	Expected with practice
Error mode	Any attempt to apply = structural failure	Error = distraction, corrected
Temporal profile	Discontinuous, unpredictable	Gradual, cumulative
Role of control	Suspended without replacement	Replaced by attentional control
Core instruction	“Do not try to improve”	“Observe without judgment”
Expected effect	Reorganization of accessible states	Regulation of existing states
Method status	Self-undermining if stabilized	Strengthens through stabilization

Table 2: Comparison between optimization-suspension and mindfulness

Dimension	Flow (high-control regime)	Reduced-control regime
Control architecture	Tight coupling between monitoring and correction	Decoupling of monitoring from correction processes
Core condition	High evaluative load with optimized control alignment	Evaluative load reduced below threshold enabling decoupling
Functional role of control	Organizes and stabilizes behavior	Constrains access to specific experiential states
Entry condition	Progressive calibration of skill, demand, and feedback	Threshold crossing via reduction of evaluative load
Transition profile	Continuous scaling of engagement	Discontinuous, all-or-none regime shift
Relation to goals	Requires explicit goals and task structure	Goal pursuit reinstates coupling and blocks access
Response to optimization	Optimization strengthens and stabilizes the regime	Any optimization attempt re-couples monitoring and correction (failure condition)
Temporal organization	Sustained through continuous feedback loops	Emerges without feedback dependence, persists transiently
Stability	Stable under maintained control loops	Metastable, collapses when coupling is reinstated
Failure mode	Breakdown under overload or mismatch	Collapse via reactivation of evaluative monitoring–correction coupling
Measurement compatibility	Compatible with monitoring and performance metrics	Measurement reinstates coupling and acts as an intervention
Strategy extraction	Strategies can be identified, refined, and reused	No strategy can be extracted without reinstating control
Variability structure	Converges toward optimal patterns over time	Remains high, non-convergent, and non-cumulative
Sensory organization	Selective enhancement of task-relevant signals	Global amplification of sensory and affective salience
Stimulus dependency	Dependent on structured task and feedback relevance	Stimuli modulate intensity only post-transition, not causal
Emotional profile	Focused engagement and absorption	High-intensity, diffuse, often somatic positive affect
Access mechanism	Scales with effort, skill, and feedback integration	Not scalable, not reproducible through effort or repetition
Causal structure of change	Incremental, reinforcement-driven improvement	Non-linear, discontinuous, and decoupled from prior actions

Table 3: Control-coupled versus control-decoupled regimes. Flow reflects an optimized high-control configuration with tight monitoring–correction coupling. The reduced-control regime emerges only when this coupling is disrupted, enabling access to experiential states that are otherwise structurally excluded.